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REL 101: Introduction to the Study of Religion

Describe religious traditions accurately before you evaluate them

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Religion & Human Relations | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack introduces the academic study of religion: key terms, the major traditions present in Nigeria, African Traditional Religion without caricature, and the method of describing before evaluating. It also covers the ethics of studying living communities.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Define religion, belief, ritual and sacred with reference to scholars.
- Compare Christianity, Islam and African Traditional Religion accurately.
- Apply the describe-then-analyse method.
- Follow ethical norms in fieldwork with religious communities.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Terms that need defining

Definitions shape what you notice.

- Religion: a contested category; substantive and functional definitions differ.
- Belief, practice, community and institution as four dimensions.
- Sacred and profane; purity, taboo and boundary.
- Ritual: repetitive, patterned action with symbolic meaning.
- Myth: a foundational narrative, not a synonym for falsehood.
- Syncretism, conversion and revival as processes, not labels.

Traditions in Nigeria

Accuracy beats generalisation.

- Christianity: denominational diversity, Pentecostal growth and independent churches.
- Islam: Maliki jurisprudence in the north, Sufi orders, reform movements.
- African Traditional Religion: a misleading singular term for diverse traditions with shared features - divination, ancestors, deities, community rites.
- Interreligious relations and conflict, and the role of the state.
- Internal diversity within every tradition; avoid treating one expression as the whole.
- Use the names communities use for themselves.

> **Describe, then evaluate**
> Describe a practice in the terms its practitioners use, then analyse it with your academic tools. Reversing the order produces caricature.

Method and ethics

Religion is studied, not proselytised.

- Bracketing: set aside your own commitments for the purposes of description.
- Use insider and outsider accounts together.
- Obtain consent before interviews and photography.
- Anonymise where disclosure could expose or endanger participants.
- Distinguish normative theology from descriptive religious studies.
- Cite sources with their tradition and date.

Studying religion without adjudicating it

Religious studies examines beliefs, practices and institutions as human phenomena. It does not require the student to accept or reject any tradition's truth claims; it requires the student to describe them accurately, explain them in context and analyse their effects. This methodological neutrality is often called bracketing, and it is a discipline, not indifference.

The field uses several approaches. Phenomenological description tries to capture how a practice appears to its practitioners. Historical analysis traces origins and change. Sociological analysis asks what religion does for and to a society. Anthropological work examines ritual, kinship and symbolism. Comparative study looks for patterns across traditions while resisting the temptation to flatten differences.

The commonest student error is apologetics in either direction - defending or attacking a tradition instead of analysing it. If your paragraph could be preached, it is not yet an academic paragraph.

Belief, practice and institution